

Raptor Center's new rehab building to make debut

By RAMONA LANDBERG
Special Correspondent

A heap of dead rats lies on the floor, thawing out. A technician hovers over a microscope, examining blood samples. A volunteer comforts an aging owl after medicating it. The smell — a combination of blood, dead animals and live animals in cramped quarters — is pervasive.

This is the Carolina Raptor Center's rehabilitation center, now housed in an aging trailer in the woods next to the headquarters. This week, staff and patients move into a new two-story, 4,000-square-foot structure that will offer all plenty of room to spread their wings.

"This is a dream that's finally become reality," said Executive Director Jim Miles, who has been on the job about two months. "We'll be able to take better care of the birds."

Until now, the rehabilitation center has been operating in the dark, cramped trailer where sick and injured birds are housed. Staff and volunteers work elbow-to-elbow to prepare meals for all the birds, perform lab work, evaluate new arrivals, administer treatments and keep charts on the patients.

There's no storage and little refrigeration. That's why the heap of dead rats, the next meal for the residents, thaws on the floor. "You have to see the old to appreciate the new," said Miles.

Across the driveway from the trailer stands the new building, which looks more like a traditional colonial home. Inside is a spacious foyer and work area.

Down the hallway leading from each side



RAMONA LANDBERG/Special to The Observer

Bill Graver, a volunteer at the Carolina Raptor Center's rehabilitation center, holds Ray Charles, a sick owl. Staff and patients are moving to a new facility.

of the foyer are an examination room, a treatment room, a laboratory, three kennel rooms for housing the birds, a walk-in freezer, laundry and cleaning room, X-ray and darkroom, education and workshop room.

Upstairs are offices, a lounge and lunch room for staff and volunteers, rooms for surgical procedures and postmortem exams, and plenty of storage space. Large windows let in plenty of light.

The new building, which cost about

\$185,000, is prefabricated, built in about two weeks' time by First Value Homes in Denver. "It came in four sections, on 18-wheelers," said Donna Eaton, the accountant for the facility. "We couldn't get anyone to build a stick-built house for that price."

Finishing touches and final inspections should be completed by Saturday's dedication. The staff expects to move in by the end of the week, but the patients under treatment won't be moved until after the open house.

"Raptors are not accustomed to being around people, and it's very stressful on them to have people around," Eaton said. "They're not cuddly."

Fund-raising for the rehabilitation center occurred over the last three or four years, Miles said. The center received substantial gifts from the Kathleen Price Bryan Family Fund, Bailey Wildlife Foundation, and the Carpenter Foundation.

It also received support from several corporations: Hoechst Celanese, Bank of America (formerly NationsBank), and Duke Power. "We'll move in debt-free," said Miles.

The center, which has an annual budget of about \$500,000, has also received donations of furniture and equipment.

The rehabilitation center's name will be announced at the ceremony as a surprise for the honoree, said Eaton.

The grand opening will be the only opportunity for most people to see the rehabilitation facility. They can tour the building at that time, but once the avian patients move in, the facility will be closed to the public.

Grand opening day is an open house for the Raptor Center as a whole. Admission is free, and the public can take conducted tours along the trail and visit the weathering area.

The Raptor Center receives about 500 sick and injured birds of prey each year. About half are eventually released into the wild. But some have suffered permanent injuries that leave them unable to hunt. Others have become imprinted on humans and unable to live in the wild. The birds that cannot be released remain at the Raptor Center.

Eaton cited Dudley, a great horned owl who became imprinted on people.

"He has a terrible case of rickets because of an improper diet in his early years," she said. People don't want to feed raptors rats and mice.

Dudley and some of the other permanent residents of the Raptor Center take part in educational programs conducted at schools throughout the Carolinas to teach children the importance of birds of prey. The Raptor Center also conducts research on raptor behavior, dietary requirements, breeding patterns and population trends.

WANT TO GO?

The dedication and grand opening of the new Raptor Rehabilitation Facility begins at 10 a.m. Saturday at the Carolina Raptor Center at Latta Plantation Nature Preserve, 6000 Sample Road, Huntersville.